purpose. Its well-planned cluster of office buildings promised larger spaces and cheaper overheads for firms and a better lifestyle for their employees. However, the SDB would work only if the entire ecosystem, with thousands of traders, moved in. That consensus amongst Mumbai diamantaires could not be achieved. Though there was a tacit arrangement with industry leaders that Mumbai-based traders could open a second office in the SDB and gradually transfer operations, that was hit by a slower than expected post-Covid recovery in the luxury goods market, which was further worsened by the Russia-Ukraine war. "Traders could not keep their word...they are looking to cut down operations, not expand," says the new chairman of SDB, Govind Dholakia, who has recently been nominated as a Rajya Sabha member by the BJP.

STILL LIFE

- **The huge, swanky Surat Diamond Bourse was meant to lure traders from Mumbai**
- **But diamantaires haven't moved in even months after it opened**
- **Slowdown in global luxury markets, lack of air connectivity with Surat and the delayed bullet train project are the main reasons**

Surat imported a third of its rough stones to polish from the Russian government-owned mining company Alrosa. With the sanctions on Russia imposed by many western nations affecting Alrosa, its exports to India have dropped, increasing the price of roughs. On the other hand, Lab Grown Diamonds (LGD) have flooded the market, causing the demand and prices of mined diamonds to plummet by a third.

A high-profile diamantaire whose skilled workforce refused to move to Surat says resignedly, "There is pressure from industry stalwarts, who in turn are under political pressure, to shift to Surat. But the diamond industry is driven by trained and trusted personnel, not machines."

Though the SDB was conceptualised in 2019, the pandemic-induced lockdown and the interminable delays in the bullet train project are thought to have reduced its appeal. Moreover, Surat's air connectivity with domestic and international destinations cannot really rival that of Mumbai.

But stakeholders are still willing to pin their hopes on the SDB's long-term future. "It took the BDB years to gather members to shift and open offices in the BKC. These are teething troubles," says Dinesh Navadiya, president of the Surat Diamond Association and a member of the SDB's core committee. SDB stalwarts have now prepared fresh strategies. For one, they are wooing local traders to move or set up small offices in the SDB. They are also looking to rent open spaces in a common trading hall where traders can sit together, like in Surat's Mahidharpura and Mini Market. "We are giving them world-class facilities at the same rate. Around 400 traders from Surat and Mumbai have confirmed they will start operations in SDB from mid-July. After the first 1,000 offices are filled up, the market will pick up on its own," Navadiya says, voicing his hope.

Bhavesh Tank, vice-president of the Surat Diamond Workers' Union, doesn't share the enthusiasm. "The key challenge is international flight connectivity and matching Mumbai's lifestyle in Surat. Both are interconnected and the primary reason for SDB's failure," he says. ■

LEFT IN THE LURCH

By Jeemon Jacob

In the aftermath of the 2024 Lok Sabha election, Kerala's political landscape has witnessed a seismic shift, leaving the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and its allies in the Left Democratic Front (LDF) reeling from an unexpected electoral blow. The defeat has not only shaken the party's confidence, but also sparked intense introspection within its ranks, as it searches for a new strategy to counter the rising tide of anti-incumbency. So much so that, in an unprecedented move, the CPI(M) leadership has openly censured the performance of the Pinarayi Vijayan government that has ruled the state since 2016, urging it to refocus on welfare measures and adopt a more people-friendly approach.

The CPI(M)'s performance in Kerala, a state long considered its bastion, was nothing short of disastrous. Out of 20 Lok Sabha seats, the party managed to clinch only one—Alathur—where K. Radhakrishnan, a popular state minister, defeated sitting Congress MP Ramya Haridas by 20,000-plus votes. This solitary victory provides little solace to the chief minister, who had led the LDF to a resounding victory in the 2021 assembly polls, securing 99 out of the state's 140 seats—despite a poor showing in the 2019 Lok Sabha election.

But now, the CPI(M)'s vote share in the state has dropped to 25.82 per cent, a tapering off from the 25.97 per cent it secured in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. Even back then, the party had won just one seat—Alappuzha—though the subsequent assembly poll victory had reignited hopes of reclaiming the parliamentary seats from the Congress. That said, the real concern for the CPI(M)